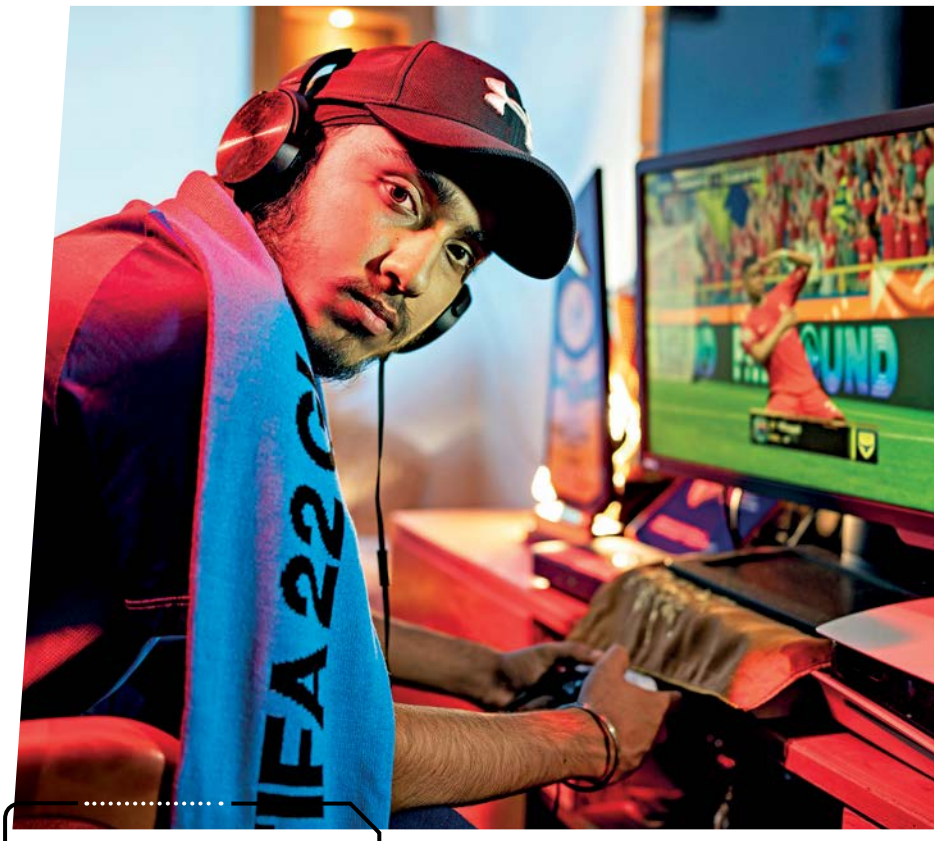
SANDEEP SAHDEV



CHARANJOT SINGH
AGE: 20
BA student at SD College, Chandigarh
PLAYING COMPETITIVELY SINCE: 2018
GAME: FIFA, part of the Asian Games contingent

Indian contingent that will compete in four of the seven video game events at the Games, to be held from September 23 to October 8. Apart from Street Fighter V, they include FIFA, Dota 2, League of Legends, Arena of Valor, Dream Three Kingdoms 2 and PUBG Mobile. These are elaborately structured games from different categories/ genres like 'multiplayer online battle arena' or MOBA (League of Legends, Dota 2, Arena of Valour), sports-based (FIFA), or 'Battle Royale' (PUBG). Like other sports, they require particular skill sets. Age-wise, the all-male Esports contingent ranges from 19 to 32 years. India cannot send representatives for Arena of Valor and PUBG Mobile to the Games because they have been inaccessible in India since September 2020 when the Centre banned them alongside 115 Chinese apps. Shedding its image as a tightly-knit online community whose individual members spend hours hunched in front of their computers in darkened rooms, gaming is now mainstream.

The latest FICCI-EY (Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce & Industry-Ernst & Young) report on India's media and entertainment industry confirms the popularity of gaming amongst youth in India, noting that the number of gamers increased from 600,000 in 2021 to a million in 2022, with another 1.5 million expected to join the fold in 2023. India is now the second largest gaming market in the world behind China, as per the 2022 India Games Market report published by Niko Partners, a market research firm. The Esports and casual gaming segment grew from Rs 2,600 crore in 2021 to Rs 3,100 crore in 2022. Whether it is Clash of Clans or Candy Crush Saga, over 50 per cent of India's internet users engage with games in some manner.

The dynamic market includes professional players like Akshaj Shenoy, skipper of the Hangzhou-bound League of Legends (or LoL) team. Shenoy's journey began at age nine, on a family-shared computer in Kochi. Soon, he developed an affinity for LoL. By 17, Shenoy convinced his parents to get him a gaming laptop. In late 2020, he began scouting for talented LoL players to form a team. Since then, they haven't lost to a South Asian team, Shenoy notes proudly.

NOT A TRIVIAL PURSUIT

Though Shenoy aspires to have a career in gaming, he is also pursuing a triple degree from St Joseph's College in Bengaluru. The 22-year-old intends to get a MBA degree and hopefully work in the HR department of a gaming company. "In India it might take time for it [gaming] to materialise [as a career]," says Shenoy. However, some have succeeded in doing that. Gamers or gaming creators (gamers who run YouTube channels) like Naman 'Mortal' Mathur, Jonathan Amaral, ScoutOP (Tanmay Singh) and Mavi have millions of followers who watch them play live on their YouTube channels and at tournaments. But unlike Shenoy, their success lies in 'shooting games' like Valorant and BGMI (Battlegrounds Mobile India) that are easier to follow than MOBA strategy games like LoL and Dota 2. Serious BGMI athletes earn an average of Rs 1-1.5 lakh a month. Creators with a following of above 500,000-1 million can make up to Rs 5 lakh a month.

If there's something that binds all Asian Games-bound gamers, it's their initial struggle to have parents understand that gaming is a serious activity, not a trivial pursuit. Given its nature—professional gamers sit for hours at the computer, honing their skills—gaming can often be viewed as a boy's own pursuit, one with an expiry date. Some are loath to acknowledge gaming as a sport.